Indeed, Grant believed that his policy of non-interference was one of the very reasons for the relatively calm proceedings of the Hijrat.[166]

For another thing, as the viceroy explained to Montagu, although led perhaps by political extremists, 'the poor misguided folk who have left their homes have left them because they genuinely thought that they were bound to do so on religious grounds. It was all important therefore that we should give no ground for the suggestion that we were interfering with a religious movement.'[167] *Once again, the Indian government was vindicated in its policy of non-interference. By late August, the Muhajirun were flocking back to India after a less than warm welcome from the Afghan government. Amanullah had been expecting more prosperous and educated Muslims to migrate to his country; when he learned that the vast majority of the Muhajirun were the poorest elements of Indian society, he quickly lost enthusiasm.*[168] *With no help from the Afghan government, and no resources of their own, the Muhajirun were forced to return home.*[169] *Reports soon spread through India of the hardship endured by the Muhajirun, many of whom died on the return journey from exhaustion and disease – the road from the Frontier to Kabul was said to be dotted with Muhajirun graves.*[170] *All together, the episode constituted a major setback for the Caliphate movement. As Grant observed, '[the] Khilafat Committee realise that they have aroused forces they cannot control and are paralysed with fear of [the] public who are bitterly resentful at having thus been duped'.*[171] *The affair was also a disaster for Amanullah, resulting as it did in a blow to his prestige across Central and southern Asia.*[172]

While the policy of the Indian government had helped avert an even bigger crisis for the British Empire, the Caliphate movement and the general Muslim unrest that was felt in South Asia in 1920 was ultimately a gift to the Bolsheviks. Not only did it create a group of captive discontents, it also allowed the Bolshevik regime to paint the British government in the light of imperialist oppressors, while posing itself as the friend and ally of the Muslim world – which was just the aim of the First Congress of the Peoples of the East, held in Baku in September 1920.[173] *According to Bolshevik figures, 1,891 delegates attended representing a number of Asian countries and various extremist movements.*[174] *(This was certainly much better attendance than its pre-cursor, the first All-Russian Congress of Muslim*